

Episode 176: *Mawaru Penguindrum* (輪るピングドラム) Colour Design

Notes – Part 3

Last week, I was caught in unexpected snow in Kyushu's Mount Aso, and this week it snowed in Tokyo! Man, snow! For a Tokyo native like me, this snow just makes me unreservedly happy. Sure, there are concerns about frozen roads the next morning and impacts on transportation, but well, that's that. I mean, it's an event that happens maybe once or twice a winter! (laugh) Let's just enjoy it with a big heart!

But January is already ending. Next week is the start of spring. Will Tokyo get more snow this winter? I'm having such irresponsible fantasies about maybe getting another snowfall that continues all day long - and I'm a 49-year-old guy thinking this! (laugh)

Now then.

Opening: Storyboard/Ikuhara Kunihiko (幾原邦彦) & Furukawa Tomohiro (古川知宏),
Direction/Ikuhara Kunihiko

Ending: Storyboard & Direction/Nakamura Akiko (中村章子)

According to my records, Episode 1 reached temporary completion (excluding the BANK scene "Crystal World") right after Golden Week in May. Then "Crystal World" was completed and Episode 1 was finished at the end of June. ...However, at this point, the opening and ending weren't completed yet. So the advance screening held in Yokohama on July 3rd, just before broadcast began, didn't have the opening and ending attached - that was the situation.

Truth be told, the opening and ending music reached us production staff in early June. Temporary versions had been delivered earlier, but with temporary tracks the arrangements differ from the actual ones, and even the song lengths themselves are different. Since openings and endings switch cuts based on the timing of the instruments

used, we can't make storyboard decisions without the actual songs. Also, depending on the arrangement, the mood of the song can be greatly affected, so we simply couldn't move forward with work until the actual songs arrived.

In any case, it was super rushed work with one month until broadcast. And in parallel, "Crystal World" was also super rushed. Naturally, work on other episodes was also proceeding steadily at a pace of one episode per week. Oh, and promotional work like posters and licencing deals were coming in too... It was such a hellish, stomach-churning June.

Now, the opening and ending. About three weeks from storyboard completion to video completion.

First, the ending. Storyboard, direction, and even all the animation were handled by Nakamura Akiko. It was just wonderful! From the planning meeting through the work process, I was grinning the whole time (laugh). Actually, I'm a huge fan of Akiko's artwork! I love her delicate yet somewhat realistic bone structure and the subtly erotic lines that somehow drift through her work. I also love watching Akiko quickly and vigorously drawing, and I often found myself staring at her working... Well, since it was artwork that Akiko had finished all the way to animation, naturally I was in charge of all the colouring (laugh).

Sanzigen handled the photography for the opening and ending. For the ending's red background, the photography team created it in advance, and we designed the character colours - or rather, the screen's aesthetic - to match it. Basically, we wanted it to look normal, but decided to bring everything together within the range of "red~pink~brown." So we made the main lines of the appearing character "Triple H" brown to blend with the background, aiming for a slightly sepia-like colour tone. This was also aimed at matching the somewhat languid feel of the ending song.

Additionally, I thought about adding "bleeding" to the main lines. Besides creating harmony with the background, I wanted to add the aesthetic of the colour illustrations

drawn by character designer Hoshino Lily (星野 リリイ). Technically, we made two copies of the main line parts, changed the blur levels on each, and overlaid them using hard light layer blending mode. When I showed the image assembled this way to Akiko for checking, it was approved in one shot (laugh). The photography team skillfully utilised this.

The opening direction was by Director Ikuhara. Actually, I don't remember having a proper meeting about this opening (laugh). The only comprehensive meeting we had was maybe the photography meeting? In terms of colour direction, it was probably just a "right!" kind of feeling with the director, and we just had casual standing conversations, talking about each cut. I went ahead and did colour direction on the incoming rough animation without hesitation.

Anyway, the opening was like a preface saying "This is the kind of story that's about to begin!" - a microcosm of the entire story, or highlight scenes, so to speak - meaningful cuts piled up like that. The composition was to show this against a basically pure white background. So the characters were basically "normal" colouring. That part was a bit easier (laugh).

Though it was a basically pure white background, this wasn't just plain white - Osakabe's designed icons were used wallpaper-style. And the director's plan was to move those icons around in various ways. The director and photography team worked together ahead of the animation to create lively icon performances. Then the animation followed after that.

The storyboard showed a certain degree of planning, but when we actually tried to do it exactly as planned, the cut length was too short for the icon movements we wanted, or when we forced everything in it became too fast to understand - we had test movies shot many times, changing direction as needed each time, and prepared each piece step by step.

On the night of July 3rd, the day of the advance screening, we first finalised the ending. Akiko, myself, and the Sanzigen team worked intensively, watching video previews of the assembled cuts while making final adjustments. Screen colour balance, overlap duration length, depth of screen processing, and so on - everyone brainstormed ideas together to finalise everything. With this, the ending was complete.

And the next night, it was time for the opening's final decision-making, with Director Ikuhara and myself visiting Sanzigen again. We had already finished rush checks on most cuts by the previous day and given them the OK, but there were a few cuts we absolutely wanted to work on - final decisions and re-shooting.

Sanzigen's 2D photography section had just been established. Actually, this *Mawaru Penguindrum* opening and ending was their first job. Yamada and Uezono were veterans who had survived countless battlefields. But with consecutive days and nights of intensive work, they were clearly showing fatigue. Even so, they raised their energy as if this was the crucial moment and were waiting for us.

The director and the two photography staff members checked previews one by one.

The opening's biggest concern was the main title cut. In After Effects, we changed the size, trajectory, and timing of the materials (character colouring data) and added various processes on top. First the director would propose changes, then Yamada from photography would add modifications. Looking at that, the director would ask "How's this?" seeking opinions from myself and Yamada, then add modifications based on those opinions. Then the director would have further ideas: "Could we do something like this?" and we'd look at that again and add everyone's opinions. Right up to this point when we had to complete and deliver everything by the morning of that day - such a session (laugh). Since every cut became more refined each time we watched the preview, participating in that serious battle was incredibly enjoyable.

Then, "Argh!" Director Ikuhara suddenly cried out. One of the monogram icons used in the background had an error. Or rather, something that was supposed to be treated as a

dummy had been used for the actual version due to a communication mistake. We hurriedly called the studio to find the correct one, but apparently the materials usable for this opening had been missed. Oh no! What should we do? But without hesitation or delay, the director and I tried to contact designer Osakabe. It was late at night... or rather, dawn. Normally he'd be sleeping at that hour, but since Osakabe had just tweeted on Twitter, we thought maybe, just maybe...

So we successfully contacted Osakabe, and he quickly finished and sent us the icon. That icon was the subway "TSM (Tokyo Sky Metro)" icon. This was actually a pretty important icon representing a certain fact that would be revealed in Episode 13. In this way, the opening was scattered with all sorts of "hidden information."

Oh yes, after the broadcast started, there was talk on the internet about the multiple "hands" appearing in the opening - someone captured RGB values from broadcast screen captures and compared them to determine "this is so-and-so's hand," which surprised me and made me laugh. Wow, that's really today's digital terrestrial and current viewers, I was impressed. Well, it is correct (laugh), but you can only do that because it's digital terrestrial - with analogue it wouldn't have been so clear, and I thought, so people care about these details! It gave me new recognition of fan psychology. Well, this wasn't exactly hidden.

So we managed to complete the TSM icon replacement. After taking breaks, work continued further, and all cuts received OK at past 5 AM. The director moved directly to the video editing studio. After adding telops to the opening and ending, *Mawaru Penguindrum* Episode 1 was truly complete.

And two days later, late at night, starting with the Kansai region, the actual broadcast of *Mawaru Penguindrum* began. Thus we stood at the new starting point of the intense, harsh battle that would continue for the next six months.

